

Building Early Critical Literacy: Fact, Opinion, Fantasy, and Reality in Grade 3 Reading

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ABSTRACT

This article examines the final two comprehension modules of Increasing Reading Power 3 as foundations for early critical literacy. Module 9 distinguishes facts, which can be proven true or false, from opinions, which express ideas or feelings and may be supported by reasons. Module 10 distinguishes fantasy, which could not occur in real life, from reality, which could occur. The source uses an adapted argumentative selection about cats to mix factual and opinion statements and a Philippine myth explaining why the sea is salty to separate real-world details from make-believe events. The analysis argues that these modules introduce two different judgment processes: evidence checking and plausibility checking. It recommends requiring learners to explain the reason for each classification so that the task moves beyond labeling toward evidence-based critical reading.

Keywords: *critical literacy, fact and opinion, fantasy and reality, Grade 3 reading, evidence, plausibility, media literacy foundations*

INTRODUCTION

The final modules of the source book ask learners to judge the status of what they read rather than only understand what happened. This represents a shift from comprehension as extraction and inference toward comprehension as evaluation. Two distinctions are emphasized: fact versus opinion and fantasy versus reality.

Although these are elementary classifications, they introduce habits that later become central to critical reading: asking whether a statement can be verified, recognizing language that signals personal judgment, and considering whether an event is possible in the real world.

Module 9: Evidence and Verifiability

Module 9 explains that a statement of fact can be proven true or false, while a statement of opinion expresses ideas or feelings and cannot be proven in the same way, although it may be supported by facts and reasons. It also introduces clues such as 'I believe,' 'I think,' and 'in my opinion.'

The selection 'Down with Cats!' is useful because it deliberately combines claims about cats with the writer's preferences. Learners are asked to identify an opinion statement, recognize a clue word, choose a statement that cannot be proved true or false, and consider appropriate ways of checking facts. The module therefore moves from definition to detection and then to rudimentary source verification.

Module 10: Plausibility and Real-World Possibility

Module 10 defines fantasy as a sentence or event that could not really happen in real life and reality as a

sentence or event that could. Its main text is the Philippine myth 'Why Is the Sea Salty?' The story includes ordinary realities, such as salt being used to preserve food and rough waves making sea travel difficult, alongside a giant whose leg can span the sea.

The activities ask learners to classify individual statements and then sort story details into reality and fantasy. The final task changes mode by asking pupils to draw examples and write two or three sentences about them.

Two Different Forms of Judgment

Question asked by the reader Fact vs. Opinion Fantasy vs. Reality

What is being judged? The evidentiary status of a statement
The real-world possibility of an event or statement

Key test Can the statement be verified as true or false?
Could this actually happen in real life?

Useful clues Evidence, sources, wording such as think/believe/opinion

Physical possibility, ordinary experience, make-believe features

Typical source text Argumentative or mixed
factual/opinion passage Myth, legend, fantasy, or realistic narrative

Expected learner response Classify and justify with evidence or wording
Classify and justify with plausibility

Why Explanation Matters

Labeling alone can hide misunderstanding. A child may correctly mark an answer as 'fact' or 'fantasy' for the

wrong reason. The strongest extension is to require a brief justification: 'This is a fact because...' or 'This is fantasy because...' Such

Five journal-style articles derived from Serdeña (2021)

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explanations make the basis of judgment visible to the teacher.

The distinction is also important because factual truth and real-world possibility are not the same test. A fictional story can contain realistic events, while an opinion can refer to something that is physically possible. Keeping the two tests separate prevents conceptual confusion.

Editorial and Instructional Considerations

Some statements in fantasy-reality activities combine an impossible character with an otherwise possible action. In such cases, the reason for classification should be made explicit. The problem is not that being afraid of ants is impossible; it is that the statement is situated around a giant in a mythic context. Explicit rationales can help learners understand which element makes the statement make-believe.

Similarly, opinion lessons benefit from distinguishing unsupported preference from a factual claim that is merely unfamiliar. The source already introduces checking books, encyclopedias, and experts; teachers can extend this by asking which source would best verify a particular statement.

Toward Later Critical and Media Literacy

At Grade 3 level, these modules are not yet a full media-literacy curriculum. However, they establish two habits that later critical literacy depends on: do not accept every

statement as equally verifiable, and do not treat every narrative event as equally realistic. These habits can later be extended to advertisements, social media, news, persuasive writing, and digital content.

LIMITATIONS

The source does not report how accurately learners distinguish these categories in actual classrooms or how well the skills transfer to unfamiliar media. The article therefore analyzes the conceptual and task design of the modules rather than their measured impact.

CONCLUSION

Modules 9 and 10 introduce young readers to two complementary forms of judgment: evidence checking and plausibility checking. Fact-opinion classification asks whether a claim can be verified; fantasy-reality classification asks whether an event could occur. Requiring learners to explain their classifications can turn these simple labels into early practices of critical reading.

REFERENCE

Serdeña, G. A. E. (2021). Increasing reading power 3.
Shirley Publishing House.